the Kaleshwaram Lift Irrigation Scheme and the Lakshminarasimha Swamy temple, KCR has tracked the construction of the new secretariat closely. The design, based on his brief, is by Chennai-based architects Oscar and Ponni Concessao. It was finalised after several days of discussions and a workshop with the CM, where he discussed in detail the master planning, vaastu principles, site grading and floor zoning. KCR has been monitoring the construction closely. The new complex is marked by classical symmetry, with a large dome, and smaller ones flanking and foregrounding it, crowning the central block. Wings radiate outwards, with domes along its length mounted atop sections.

The exterior architectural character of the building is intended to reflect the diverse cultures of Telangana. The podium cladding, 15 feet high, is made of red sandstone; beige Dholpur stone from Rajasthan is used in the central tower. The domes are inspired by the temples and palaces of Telangana. "The design inspiration is twofold. One is the harmonious blend of Telangana's architectural heritage. The other is Lord Shiva, with specific reference to the Neelakanteshwara temple near Hyderabad and the Wanaparthy Palace," explains Ponni Concessao.

The entire complex will be fenced by 16-feet-high designer metal grills. The scale of the rectilinear building, 600 feet by 300 feet in dimension, and its seven floors, each 14 feet high, is imposingly monumental. The main entry is in the east, with an exclusive entrance and lift for the chief minister to take him to the topmost floor, where his large, glass-panelled office is in the southwest corner. A sky lounge below the central dome also showcases a 360-degree view of the Hussain Sagar Lake nearby and Hyderabad city.

VAASTU AND MODERN TECHNOLOGY

Accommodating KCR's devout belief in vaastu principles posed challenges, which were resolved through on-site discussions, apparently without compromising on functional and security necessities. "We had to design the several spatial components and the facades, update drawings and present several options on a daily basis for almost two weeks," recalls architect Oscar G. Concessao. KCR pored over the plans once or twice a week.

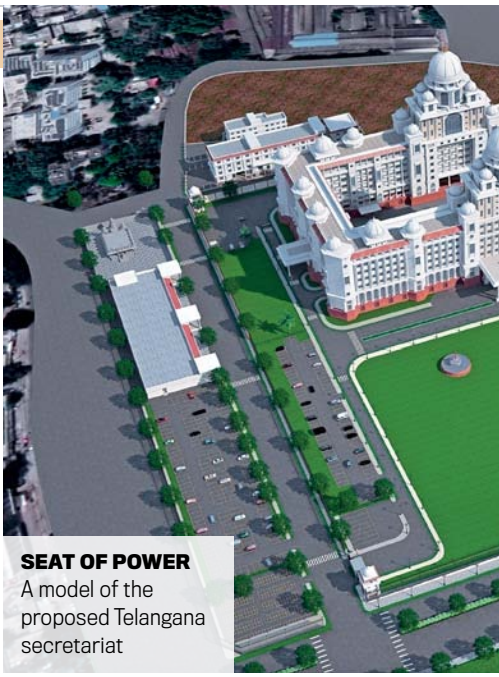
The distribution of entrances and service core areas, lifts, staircases, utility rooms, toilets and the directions all apparently adhere to the tenets of vaastu. For example, while all 106 assistant secretaries are eligible for an attached toilet in their offices, the number of these facilities has been reduced "to avoid imbalance". Again, the building mostly adheres to the vaastu principle that a staircase should be ascended from east to west or from north to south, but this could not be followed in every instance, keeping in mind the functionality of the building.

At ground zero, there is a central courtyard—the *brahmasthanam*—designed for proper ventilation and wind movement. More than half the 29.5 acre site will be landscaped with lawns and fountains, and gardens will be planted with local trees.

WHILE SOME BUILDING LAWS WERE MODIFIED TO SUIT VAASTU BELIEFS, THE BUILDING WILL ALSO HAVE THE LATEST TECHNOLOGY

The secretariat will, of course, be equipped with latest technology: smart lighting controls with motion sensors, timers, automated switches, dimming controls and energy efficient equipment are being installed. Materials including granite, vitrified tiles, veneer wood paneling, metal and acoustic false ceilings, energy-efficient plumbing fixtures are being used for the interiors. Vitrified flooring will be used at all levels, except in the CM's office and the entire sixth floor, which will have marble floors. Green building concepts are being implemented using eco-friendly materials with low embodied energy. The aim is to reduce artificial lighting and increase natural ventilation.

With the southwest corner, as per vaastu shastra, guaranteeing continuity, most ministers' offices will be in that direction. The lower floors will accommodate meeting halls, waiting areas, the reception centre and record rooms. An exclusive conference room with a capacity to seat over 200 people, suitable for large administrative meetings with



SEAT OF POWER
A model of the proposed Telangana secretariat